

11.1.1 ID3v1

Prior to the ‘invention’ (or as they say in software, ‘development’) of ID3 tags, the only information about the contents of an MP3 file that could be saved on the MP3 file were some simple yes/no parameters like ‘private’ and ‘copyrighted’.

Then one day in 1996 this guy called Eric Kemp decided that he really wanted to know which artist he was listening to, and from which album the song that he was listening to was, and, basically, other related information about the track as well. So he developed a program called Studio 3, which added a small amount (128 bytes) of data to the MP3 file itself. This ‘tag’ was added to the end of the file so that it did not disturb how the media player played back the track. A 128 byte ID3 tag has the following information

- Song title: 30 characters (one byte each)
- Artist: 30 characters
- Album: 30 characters
- Comment: 30 characters
- Year: 4 characters
- Genre: 1 byte

Technically, if you add it all up, it comes up to 125 bytes. The remaining 3 bytes are ‘TAG’ which is basically, how the media player identifies an ID3 tag! Initially, some media players played a tiny blip of static when they read the tag part of the file but all current players will skip it. Eric Kemp made the byte value of the genre field correspond with one of 80 pre-defined genres.

11.1.1.1 ID3v1.1

Sometime after the ID3v1 tag was developed, another guy, called Michael Mutschler decided that it would be a good idea to know what was the order in which the MP3 files from a particular album were on the album CD itself. So, he used the last byte from the comments field, which hardly anyone used, to store the track number of the MP3 file.